

Grant Opportunities for AI-Supported Community Design and Resilience

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Executive Summary

The strongest grant strategy is a portfolio, not a single application. The core idea should be framed as a Northern California community design lab that uses responsible AI, student studios, professional design practice, and civic partners to accelerate resilient, affordable, and age-friendly rebuilding. The work can credibly connect four urgent problems: wildfire recovery and home hardening, post-disaster rebuilding in Paradise and similar communities, aging in place, and homelessness or housing instability.

- **Best immediate AI-aligned target:** OpenAI Foundation People-First AI Fund, reopening June 15, 2026, with a new \$50M commitment; also track the \$250M Economic Futures program for larger pilots later in 2026. [S6, S7]
- **Best immediate wildfire target:** CAL FIRE Wildfire Prevention Grants, open through July 8, 2026, for locally led resilience, education, evacuation, fuels, and preparedness work. [S9]
- **Best large public-infrastructure targets:** FEMA BRIC due July 23, 2026, and California DR-INF/MIT-RIP due July 10, 2026, but these require a state/local government lead. [S10, S13]
- **Best homelessness/housing targets:** Homekey+ rolling applications, HUD CoC/YHDP due August 26, 2026, HHAP subgrant partnerships, and AHSC for housing-plus-mobility. [S14-S17, S20]
- **Best local proof-of-concept funder:** North Valley Community Foundation Camp Fire Fund, reopening November 2026 with possible special inquiries before then. [S19]

Why Rouben Is a Strong Principal Investigator / Community Design Lead

Rouben Mohiuddin is publicly positioned as both a practicing design professional and a CSU Chico Interior Architecture professor. Design SI describes him as founder of the firm, with more than 25 years of architecture and design experience, a B.A. in Environmental Design, an M.Arch. from SCI-Arc, and prior teaching experience at UCLA, Otis, and the New York School of Interior Design. CSU Chico lists him as Professor of Interior Architecture in the Art and Art History Department and describes over 30 years of experience, sustainable design practice, and community-focused design initiatives. [S1, S2]

Most importantly for this grant package, Rouben already has a documented Camp Fire / Rebuild Paradise track record. Rebuild Paradise describes the Flumes master plan as emerging from listening sessions hosted by CSU Chico Interior Architecture, with Rouben, student volunteers, Design SI, and Rancho Engineering supporting community input and code-compliant plans. Chico State coverage similarly describes free floor plans for wildfire survivors and notes that Rouben took plans through approval and permitting with Design SI so rebuilding could be more streamlined. [S3, S4]

Recommended Umbrella Concept

North State Resilient Living Lab: AI-supported design modules for fire-resilient, age-friendly, and housing-stable communities.

The lab would combine a CSU Chico curriculum/studio sequence, Design SI professional supervision, community listening sessions, and partner-led pilots. Students would learn AI-assisted workflows for precedent research, code-aware design checklists, material and cost comparisons, visual iteration, accessibility audits, home-hardening guidance, and communication packets for residents and agencies. The grant narrative should stress that AI supports research, iteration, translation, and decision support; it does not replace authorship, professional judgment, building-code review, or community consent.

- **Fire resilience/rebuilding:** AI-assisted home hardening, defensible-space education, rebuild plan variants, insurance-ready resilience documentation, and faster resident-facing design packets.

- **Aging in place:** accessible, low-cost home modification templates, ADU/multigenerational options, smoke/heat refuge upgrades, fall-risk and mobility audits.
- **Homelessness:** modular/supportive-housing site concepts, adaptive reuse visualization, service-adjacent layouts, and community engagement materials that help public agencies and nonprofits move projects faster.
- **Workforce/economic transition:** train design students and local workforce partners to use AI responsibly in architecture, planning, construction documentation, client communication, and public-service workflows.

Ranked Opportunity Matrix

Priority	Opportunity	Timing / Size	Fit and Approach
1	OpenAI Foundation People-First AI Fund	Applications reopen June 15, 2026; new \$50M commitment. [S7]	Pitch a people-first AI design education and community resilience pilot. Emphasize co-creation, practical benefits, local capacity, and underserved communities.
2	OpenAI Foundation Economic Futures in the Age of AI	\$250M initial commitment; first initiatives expected later in 2026. [S6]	Submit as an economic transition/workforce pilot: AI changes design, construction, public planning, and community service delivery. Frame as regional workforce resilience.
3	CAL FIRE Wildfire Prevention Grants	Up to \$70M statewide; applications due July 8, 2026. [S9]	Lead through a public agency, Fire Safe Council, nonprofit, or tribal partner. Fit: community education, evacuation readiness, defensible space, chipping days, resident-facing design guidance.
4	FEMA BRIC	\$1B national; close July 23, 2026; max listed \$150M; match required. [S10]	Large mitigation infrastructure, warning, evacuation, community facility hardening. CSU/Design SI should be a technical/community engagement subpartner under Butte County, Paradise, or state applicant.
5	California DR-INF/MIT-RIP	Due July 10, 2026. [S13]	For disaster-impacted local governments rebuilding infrastructure resiliently. Position the lab as planning/design support for wildfire, flood, and earthquake risk reduction.
6	Homekey+ / Prop 1	\$2.2B program; rolling review; \$1B+ still available in May 2026. [S14, S15]	For permanent supportive housing serving people at risk of or experiencing homelessness with behavioral health challenges and veterans. Design SI/CSU can support modular/adaptive reuse concepts.
7	HUD FY 2026 CoC / YHDP	Applications due Aug. 26, 2026. [S16]	Go through the local Continuum of Care. Fit: supportive housing design, youth homelessness, service navigation, and evaluation; not a solo CSU application.
8	NVCF Camp Fire Fund	Annual cycle reopens Nov. 2026; special inquiries possible. [S19]	Best local seed funding for Paradise/Camp Fire footprint demonstration, community workshops, prototype plan sets, or resident design clinics.
9	AARP Community Challenge	2026 cycle closed Mar. 4; annual quick-action grants; 2026 awards up to \$25K. [S18]	Prepare for 2027. Strong for aging-in-place, disaster preparedness, home-modification capacity building, and housing choice design competitions.
10	NSF CIVIC / S&CC;	Research-action programs; monitor next active cycle. [S21, S22]	Good for rigorous community-university pilots using AI/data/design to improve resilience, housing, public health, or services. Needs research questions and evaluation design.
11	Patrick J. McGovern Foundation	Rolling/relationship-driven foundation; recent AI, climate, workforce, and housing-resilience grants. [S23]	Prospect for philanthropic support after a small pilot exists. Strong fit if the work becomes open-source civic AI/design infrastructure.
12	Google.org / data.org AI challenges	Some 2026 calls closed, but useful templates for future cycles. [S24, S25]	Track future AI-for-government/economic opportunity calls. Requires public-sector partnership and measurable deployment, not just curriculum.

How to Approach the Grants

1. Build the applicant coalition before writing.

For most large public grants, the applicant should not be Design SI alone. The likely lead should be CSU Chico for education/research funds; Butte County, Town of Paradise, City of Chico, or a housing authority for FEMA/HCD infrastructure and housing funds; a Continuum of Care or service provider for homelessness; and a Fire Safe Council or recovery nonprofit for wildfire preparedness. Design SI and CSU Interior Architecture become named implementation partners with clear scopes: community workshops, design studios, concept packages, accessibility/fire-resilience audits, AI workflow training, and evaluation support.

2. Lead with community outcomes, not AI.

The fundable problem is not 'students using AI.' The fundable problem is that rural Northern California communities face slow, expensive, confusing rebuilding; older adults need safe homes; wildfire smoke and fire risk are recurring public health threats; and housing instability/homelessness demand faster, more trusted design and implementation pathways. AI should be the capacity multiplier: faster research, clearer options, better visualization, resident-facing guidance, multilingual materials, and more disciplined evaluation.

3. Package three proposal lanes.

- **Lane A: Fast pilot, \$25K-\$250K.** Community workshops, student modules, design sprints, prototype templates, AI literacy, resident guidance. Targets: OpenAI People-First, NVCF, AARP 2027, local foundations.
- **Lane B: Applied public program, \$250K-\$2M.** Fire-resilient/age-friendly design clinic, cleaner-air/community facility upgrades, pilot supportive-housing concepts, workforce training. Targets: CAL FIRE, EPA next cycle, NSF CIVIC, philanthropic AI funds.
- **Lane C: Capital/infrastructure, \$2M-\$50M+.** Permanent supportive housing, resilient infrastructure, modular rebuilding, community facility hardening. Targets: Homekey+, AHSC, BRIC, DR-INF/MIT-RIP, CoC. CSU/Design SI support, but civic partner leads.

Specific Project Ideas

AI Resilient Rebuild Studio

A CSU Chico Interior Architecture sequence where students and Design SI produce community-vetted plan variants for fire-resilient, insurable, accessible homes and ADUs. Outputs: design templates, cost ranges, code/resilience checklists, and resident presentation packets.

Paradise Aging-in-Place + Fire Hardening Clinics

A mobile clinic for older adults and low-income homeowners: home safety/accessibility audits, defensible-space education, smoke-readiness upgrades, and prioritized modification plans that can be used for future repair or retrofit funding.

Supportive Housing Rapid Concept Lab

A design and community engagement service for CoC, housing authority, and nonprofit partners pursuing Homekey+, CoC, or AHSC projects. Outputs: adaptive reuse concepts, modular unit layouts, service adjacency plans, public meeting visuals, and resident dignity standards.

North State AI Workforce Pathway for Community Design

A responsible-AI training pathway for students, local designers, construction partners, public agencies, and nonprofits. The deliverable is a practical playbook for AI-assisted public-interest design that includes ethics, privacy, authorship, and professional review.

Cleaner Air + Resilience Hubs

Assess community-serving buildings for wildfire smoke and heat readiness; create upgrade packages for filtration, weatherization, signage, operations, and communication. Best paired with EPA next cycle, CAL FIRE, BRIC, or local recovery funds.

90-Day Action Plan

- **Week 1:** Confirm lead partners and eligibility: CSU Chico sponsored programs, Town of Paradise/Butte County, local CoC, Rebuild Paradise, Fire Safe Council, NVCF, True North/CHIP/Habitat-type housing partners.
- **Week 2:** Draft a 2-page concept note with problem statement, target populations, AI use policy, workplan, outcomes, and partner roles. Use it for funder conversations.
- **Weeks 2-4:** Submit/prepare near-term opportunities: OpenAI People-First when it opens June 15, CAL FIRE by July 8 if a partner can lead, DR-INF/MIT-RIP by July 10 if local government fit exists, BRIC by July 23 only if the government partner already has a mature mitigation project.
- **Weeks 4-8:** Build a pilot dataset and evidence file: Camp Fire rebuild history, community listening notes, sample plan packages, estimated time/cost savings, accessibility/fire-hardening checklist, and letters of support.
- **Weeks 8-12:** Prepare a larger fall/winter funding package for NVCF, NSF-style research programs, philanthropic AI funders, AARP 2027, and housing capital programs.

Grant Narrative That Should Score Well

One-sentence pitch: We will build a responsible AI-supported community design lab at CSU Chico that helps Northern California communities recover from wildfire, age safely at home, and move vulnerable residents into dignified housing faster by combining community listening, professional design supervision, student learning, and replicable public-interest design tools.

- **Equity:** Prioritize Camp Fire survivors, older adults, low-income homeowners, veterans, people with behavioral health challenges, and residents experiencing or at risk of homelessness.
- **Replicability:** Turn each pilot into reusable modules: curriculum, templates, checklists, evaluation instruments, and partner playbooks.
- **Responsible AI:** Keep humans accountable. AI supports research and options generation; professional and civic partners validate code, safety, ethics, privacy, and final decisions.
- **Measurable outcomes:** number of residents served, plans produced, workshops held, student competencies gained, partner applications supported, dollars leveraged, retrofit/housing projects advanced, and time saved.
- **Why now:** OpenAI and other funders are explicitly seeking community-shaped AI applications, while California has active wildfire, housing, homelessness, and resilience funding windows in summer 2026.

Sources

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[S3] Rebuild Paradise - CSU, Chico / Design SI / Rancho Engineering

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[S4] Chico State Helps Rebuild Communities

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[S5] CSU Interior Architecture Program

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[S11] US Forest Service Community Wildfire Defense Grant Program

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[S12] EPA Wildfire Smoke Preparedness in Community Buildings

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[S13] California HCD DR-INF/MIT-RIP

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[S14] California HCD Homekey+

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[S15] HCD Homekey+ May 2026 Awards / Prop 1 Funding

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[S16] HUD FY 2026 CoC and YHDP NOFO

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[S18] AARP 2026 Community Challenge

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[S19] North Valley Community Foundation Camp Fire Fund

<https://www.nvcf.org/buttestrongfund>

[S20] California SGC Affordable Housing and Sustainable Communities

<https://sgc.ca.gov/grant-programs/ahsc/>

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